

FREE BONUS

The Complete Body Lotion & Cream Guide

Understand the "why" behind mixing oil and water, not just one recipe to follow.

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SECTION 1

What Makes a Lotion Different From a Body Butter

You'll understand why lotions need a different skill than the anhydrous recipes in your bundle, and why that skill is worth learning.

A body butter is just oils and butters whipped together — no water, so nothing to hold together. A lotion is water AND oil in the same bottle, two things that naturally separate, held together by an emulsifier. That's the entire skill this guide teaches.

Why most people never try it

- 1 **It looks like just "adding water to oil."** It isn't — without the right emulsifier and the right temperatures, you get a bottle of salad dressing that separates in an hour.
- 2 **It needs a real preservative.** Anhydrous recipes don't. The moment water enters the bottle, mold and bacteria have what they need to grow, and that changes everything about how you make and store the product.
- 3 **It rewards following steps in order.** Lotion-making is one of the few places in DIY body care where skipping a step (like matching temperatures) reliably ruins the batch.

The payoff

Once you understand the three phases in Section 2, every lotion and cream recipe — anyone's, not just this bundle's — stops being a mystery.

SECTION 2

The Three Phases of an Emulsion

You'll know what goes in each phase of a lotion, and why the order and temperature matter.

Every basic lotion is built from three phases, always combined in the same order.

PHASE	WHAT'S IN IT	WHY IT'S SEPARATE
Oil phase	Oils, butters, emulsifying wax, any oil-soluble ingredient	These need gentle heat to melt and combine
Water phase	Distilled water, aloe juice, hydrosols, any water-based liquid	Heated separately so it matches the oil phase's temperature
Cool-down phase	Preservative, essential oils, vitamin E, anything heat-sensitive	Added only once the emulsion has cooled, so heat doesn't destroy them

Step by step

- 1 Weigh both phases separately** — oil phase in one heatproof container, water phase in another.
- 2 Heat both to the same temperature** — typically 160-170°F (70-77°C), checked with a thermometer in each. This is the single most important step: pouring hot oil into cold water (or the reverse) is the #1 cause of a broken, separated lotion.
- 3 Pour the water phase into the oil phase** in a thin stream while blending (a small immersion blender or milk frother works better than a whisk for a stable emulsion).
- 4 Keep blending as it cools** — in short bursts, every minute or two, until it reaches room temperature. This is what keeps it from separating later.
- 5 Add the cool-down phase** only once the lotion is below 110°F (43°C) — add the preservative at its label's exact rate, then any essential oil or vitamin E.

Common mistake

Stopping blending too early. A lotion that looks done at 90°F (32°C) can still separate overnight if it wasn't blended through the whole cooling window.

SECTION 3

Choosing an Emulsifier

You'll know which emulsifier to reach for and roughly how much to use.

The emulsifier is what actually holds the water and oil together — skip it, or guess at the amount, and no amount of blending will save the batch.

EMULSIFIER TYPE	TYPICAL USE RATE	GOOD FOR
Emulsifying wax NF	3-6% of the total batch weight	Beginners — forgiving, widely available, gives a classic lotion texture
Plant-derived emulsifier (e.g. a cetearyl-based "natural" emulsifying wax)	4-7% of the total batch weight	A lighter, slightly less greasy finish
Lecithin-based emulsifier	2-4% of the total batch weight	Very light lotions and facial creams, more advanced to stabilize

Before you buy an emulsifier

- ☐ Check the label's own recommended use rate — rates vary by brand, this table is a starting range
- ☐ Start with emulsifying wax NF for your first few batches
- ☐ Buy a small amount first — a little goes a long way, and you'll want to test before committing to a big batch

SECTION 4

The Preservative Is Not Optional

You'll understand exactly why every water-containing product needs one, and how to use it correctly.

This is the one section in this guide that matters more than any other: any product with water in it can grow mold, yeast or bacteria, often with no visible or smell change until it's already a problem.

What to actually do

- 1 **Use a broad-spectrum preservative** made for cosmetics, rated for the pH range of your lotion (most are rated for pH 3-8, which covers a typical lotion).
- 2 **Use it at the exact rate on its own label** — usually somewhere between 0.5% and 1% of the total batch weight, but this varies by product, so the label is the real source, not this guide.
- 3 **Add it in the cool-down phase**, below 110°F (43°C) — heat can break down some preservatives before they ever get the chance to work.
- 4 **Weigh it**, don't eyeball it — a kitchen scale that reads to 0.1 g is worth owning for this one step alone.

What doesn't count as a preservative

Vitamin E, grapefruit seed extract, and most essential oils are not reliable broad-spectrum preservatives. Vitamin E slows oils from going rancid — it does not stop mold or bacteria in a water-based product. Don't substitute them for a real preservative.

SECTION 5

Your First Basic Lotion, Step by Step

You'll make one complete, working lotion from start to finish, using everything from the sections above.

This single recipe is the "home base" you can adjust later — it uses middle-of-the-range amounts for every ingredient discussed so far.

Ingredients (about 8 oz / 225 g)

PHASE	INGREDIENT	AMOUNT
Oil	Sweet almond oil	40 g (1.4 oz)
Oil	Emulsifying wax NF	12 g (0.4 oz)
Water	Distilled water	160 g (5.6 oz)
Cool-down	Broad-spectrum preservative	per label, typically 1-2 g
Cool-down	Essential oil (optional)	15-20 drops

Step by step

- 1 Weigh the oil phase** (almond oil + emulsifying wax) into one heatproof container, and the water phase (distilled water) into another.
- 2 Heat both** in a double boiler, or separate cups set in a pan of simmering water, until both read 160-170°F (70-77°C) on a thermometer.
- 3 Pour the water into the oil** in a thin stream, blending the whole time with a small immersion blender.
- 4 Keep blending in short bursts** every 1-2 minutes as it cools, for about 15-20 minutes total, until it reaches room temperature and looks like a finished lotion.
- 5 Add the preservative** once it's under 110°F (43°C), weighed at the exact rate its label states, and blend briefly to combine.

6 Add the **essential oil**, if using, and blend once more.

7 Pour into a **clean bottle or pump** and label with the date made.

You'll know it worked if

- ☐ It's smooth and pourable, with no separate layer of oil on top after a day
- ☐ It still looks and smells the same after a week at room temperature
- ☐ It spreads easily and absorbs without feeling greasy after a minute or two

SECTION 6

Troubleshooting a Broken or Grainy Batch

You'll recognize the three most common lotion problems and know exactly what caused each one.

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX NEXT TIME
It separated into an oily layer on top	The two phases weren't the same temperature when combined, or blending stopped too early during cooling	Check both temperatures with a thermometer before combining; keep blending every 1-2 min until fully cool
It's grainy or has little white specks	The emulsifying wax didn't fully melt, or the mixture cooled too fast in a cold container	Make sure the oil phase is fully clear and liquid before combining; use a room-temperature container
It's too thin and runny	Not enough emulsifying wax for the amount of oil, or too much water	Increase the emulsifying wax slightly next batch, within its label's recommended range
It's too thick to pump	Too much emulsifying wax or oil relative to water	Reduce the oil phase slightly, or switch to a jar instead of a pump bottle
It smells off after a few days, even refrigerated	No preservative, too little, or added while the mixture was still too hot	Re-check the preservative's rate and that it was added below 110°F (43°C); when in doubt, remake it — don't use a batch that smells wrong

SECTION 7

Customizing From This Base

You'll be able to turn the basic lotion from Section 5 into other products using the same method.

Once the base ratio works for you, small changes turn it into different products — the method from Sections 2-4 never changes.

- 1 **Thicker hand or face cream** — increase the oil phase to about 35-40% of the total batch weight (instead of this guide's lighter lotion ratio), keeping the same emulsifier percentage.
- 2 **Lighter, more liquid lotion** — reduce the oil phase slightly and increase the water phase, staying within your emulsifier's labeled range.
- 3 **Added slip and glide** — replace 5-10 g of the water phase with aloe vera juice.
- 4 **A calming, fragrance-free version** — simply skip the essential oil in the cool-down phase; everything else stays the same.

Keep a batch log

Write down the exact weights you used each time, in a notebook or your phone. When a batch turns out exactly right, that log is the only way to repeat it.

Next Step

Open the Recipe Library app and try the method on a real recipe: the Emulsified Body Scrub category uses the same oil-water-preserved logic you just learned, at a smaller, simpler scale.